

**BEFORE THE PUBLIC UTILITIES COMMISSION
OF THE STATE OF CALIFORNIA**

Order Instituting Rulemaking to
Establish Energization Timelines.

Rulemaking 24-01-018
(Filed January 25, 2024)

**REPLY COMMENTS OF THE VEHICLE-GRID INTEGRATION COUNCIL ON
PHASE 1 SCOPING MEMO ISSUES**

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Date: May 17, 2024

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In accordance with the Rules of Practice and Procedure of the California Public Utilities Commission (“Commission”), the Vehicle-Grid Integration Council (“VGIC”)¹ hereby submits these reply comments on the *Assigned Commissioner’s Scoping Memo and Ruling* (“Scoping Memo”) and *Email Ruling Adjusting Phase 1 Schedule and Addressing the April 2, 2024 Joint Investor Owned Utilities’ Motion* issued by Administrative Law Judge (“ALJ”) Carolyn Sisto on March 28, 2024 and April 8, 2024, respectively.

I. INTRODUCTION.

In Opening Comments on Phase 1, many parties outlined their work towards meeting transportation electrification mandates and goals largely set by the California Air Resources Board (“CARB”) but highlighted that a barrier to achieving these goals is the current energization timelines for electric vehicle charging infrastructure. Achieving timely energization to enable the needed vehicle electrification will require many modifications to the way California’s investor-

¹ VGIC member companies and supporters include American Honda Motor Co., Inc., BorgWarner, Fermata Energy, Ford Motor Company, General Motors, Nissan Group of North America, Bidirectional Energy, Customized Energy Solutions, dcbel, Eaton Corporation, Emporia Corp., EnergyHub, EV.Energy, FreeWire Technologies, Inc., GridWiz, Kaluza, Landis + Gyr, Leapfrog Power, Inc., Nuvve Holding Corporation, Peak Power, PowerFlex, Qcells, Stellantis N.V., Sumitomo Electric, The Mobility House, Toyota Motor North America, Inc., WeaveGrid, Hoosier Energy, Peninsula Clean Energy, and Sacramento Municipal Utility District. The views expressed in these Comments are those of VGIC, and do not necessarily reflect the views of all individual VGIC member companies or supporters.
(<https://www.vgicouncil.org/>)

owned utilities (“IOU”) have historically planned for energization of new load and distribution upgrades more generally.

The establishment of energization timelines will help to push the IOUs to move more quickly and will also provide customers with expected timelines they can plan around. However, as discussed by many parties, many energization projects, especially medium- and heavy-duty charging stations, require larger, multi-year distribution upgrades that are harder to establish standard timelines for.² Even if distribution upgrade timelines are established, reasonable timelines that are achievable by the IOUs may last multiple years for some sites, and interim or alternative energization solutions will be needed. For this reason, the Commission must include flexible service connection solutions in the initial energization timelines and reporting requirements set by Phase 1 of this proceeding.

II. MULTIPLE PARTIES SUPPORT INCLUDING FLEXIBLE SERVICE CONNECTION IN ENERGIZATION TIMELINES.

VGIC reiterates the importance of having utilities offer flexible service connection (e.g., automated load management (“ALM”) solutions) to customers with exceptionally long energization timelines, as well as tracking use of these strategies in energization timeline reporting, which was supported by multiple parties in opening comments. As highlighted by Advanced Energy United (“United”), “the establishment of timelines should incorporate the necessary discussion and consideration between the customer and utility, and potentially for bifurcated or reduced steps in the process,”³ including flexible service connection solutions. Calls for

² The Joint IOUs have outlined that distribution capacity upgrade timelines “will vary greatly by upgrade, based upon the variables that are unique to that upgrade.” See *San Diego Gas & Electric Company (U 902-E)*, *Pacific Gas and Electric Company (U 39 E)*, and *Southern California Edison Company (U 338-E) Response to Administrative Law Judge Ruling Directing Utility Responses to Questions Regarding Energization Timelines* at 5.

³ United Opening Comments at 13.

consideration and tracking of flexible connection were echoed by the Environmental Defense Fund (“EDF”) and Natural Resources Defense Council (“NRDC”),⁴ Powering America’s Commercial Transportation (“PACT”),⁵ Terrawatt Infrastructure,⁶ and Voltera.⁷

Based on this strong stakeholder support, VGIC believes that, at a minimum, tracking the deployment of these flexible service connection solutions should be included in Phase 1 timelines. VGIC’s suggested items to include in timeline reporting were outlined in opening comments and include: (1) whether flexible connection solutions were proposed or accepted, (2) the type of flexible connection, and (3) the type of flexible connection technology used.⁸ In addition to tracking data regarding flexible service connection, VGIC also supports the proposal from EDF and NRDC for the IOUs to include “discussion of the process improvement progress completed in the prior year, discussion of the customer-specific solutions (e.g. deployment of distributed energy resources and flexible interconnection agreements) the utility has offered to customers and/or deployed in the prior year, those solutions’ effectiveness at shortening customer-specific timelines, and any staffing changes made to implement these solutions and shorten the timelines.”⁹ Written discussion on the IOUs’ experience implementing these solutions will provide valuable insights as timelines are updated and as the Commission considers broader implications for distribution planning and ratepayer costs. As highlighted by Advanced Energy United, flexible service connections can “avoid or defer grid upgrades and to reduce costs and maximize the efficient use of existing infrastructure.”¹⁰ Discussion on the implementation of these solutions can show how these solutions are providing cost savings to ratepayers and will inform how the IOUs should plan

⁴ EDF and NDRC Opening Comments at 6.

⁵ PACT Opening Comments at 5.

⁶ Terrawatt Infrastructure Opening Comments at 3.

⁷ Voltera Opening Comments at 6.

⁸ See additional detail in VGIC Opening Comments at 6-8.

⁹ EDF and NRDC Opening Comments at 10.

¹⁰ United Opening Comments at 11.

for large loads as California seeks to electrify. **However, VGIC emphasizes that narrative discussion detailing process improvements is a complement – not a substitute – to regular energization timelines and flexible service connection data reporting.**

III. CONCLUSION.

VGIC appreciates the opportunity to provide these reply comments on Phase 1 of this proceeding. We look forward to further collaboration with the Commission and stakeholders on this initiative.

Respectfully submitted,

/s/ Zach Woogen

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Interim Executive Director

VEHICLE-GRID INTEGRATION COUNCIL

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